

Arabic, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/arabic/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Arabic volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Arabic letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, right-to-left, so you learn to read سلام *and* learn that it means “peace” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Arabic simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Arabic changes the etymology game entirely. The Romance and Germanic volumes trace words back to Latin or Germanic roots; Arabic doesn’t need tracing — its roots are on the *surface*. Nearly every Arabic word is built from a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed patterns, so *peace*, *Islam*, *Muslim*, and the greeting *salaam* are visibly one family (s-l-m), the way this whole series wishes Latin were. That root system is taught as the organizing engine. A recurring thread is Arabic’s long shadow over **Spanish**, another language in this project: the article *al-* smuggled into English *algebra* and *alcohol*, and the sun-letter assimilation still audible in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*) — every such form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of Spanish is assumed.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest honest web of connections; the cultural or grammatical reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Pronunciation & Script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system. Arabic appears both in script (مرحبا) and in transliteration (*marḥaban*), a dot marking the heavy/throaty consonants.

The script, in one breath

- **Right to left**, and letters **connect** — each has up to four shapes (isolated/initial/medial/final). Met inside real words, not drilled.
- Short vowels (*a i u*) are usually left unwritten; long vowels (*ā ī ū*) are letters (ا و ي).

Consonants with no English equivalent

- ح (ḥ): a heavy *h* from deep in the throat (vs. light ه).
- خ (kh): a throat-scrape = Scottish *loch*, **Spanish** *j*.
- ع (‘, “*ayn*”): a voiced throat-tightening; no English match.
- ء (‘, “hamza”): a glottal stop — the catch in “uh-oh.”
- ق (q): a *k* made far back; غ (gh): a gargled *g*.

Emphatic (“heavy”) consonants

ص ض ط ظ (ṣ, ḍ, ṭ, ṣ): heavier, deeper versions of *s*, *d*, *t*, *dh*. They change the word: ص س ≠ س *s*.

The article and sun/moon letters

ال (*al-*, “the”) attaches to its noun. Before a **sun letter** the *l* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al-salām* → *as-salām*. Before a **moon letter** it stays: *al-khayr*. The sun rule is fossilized in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*).

The root system

Most words are built on a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into vowel **patterns**: *k-t-b* (writing) → *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office). See the first lesson.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Arabic greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Arabic script and how the three-consonant **root** builds nearly every word. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: `lessons/AR-C01-*.md`.*

Three facts about the script, and one about the roots

1. **Right to left.** The first letter of a word is on the *right*.
2. **Letters connect** (cursive-style), so a letter’s shape shifts a little by position; a few are “one-way” — they join the letter before but not the one after.
3. **Short vowels are usually invisible.** Long vowels ($\bar{a}$ $\bar{i}$ $\bar{u}$) are full letters; the short $a/i/u$ between consonants are simply known, not written.

And the engine of the whole language: most Arabic words are a **root** of three consonants carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed vowel **patterns**. The classic is **k–t–b** (writing): *kataba* (he wrote), *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office = “a place of writing”), *maktaba* (library) — six words, one root. Every greeting below is a root plus a pattern; watch the roots surface.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — “peace,” the most famous root

The letters in this word

Four letters, read **right to left**: س (*sīn*, “s”), ل (*lām*, “l”), ا (*alif*, long “ā”), م (*mīm*, “m”). Warm up on the tiny word لا (*lā*, “no”) — *lām* then *alif*, fusing into one shape — then read سلام right to left: *s · l · ā · m* → *salām*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سلام (*salām*), “peace.” Root **s-l-m** (*wholeness, safety, peace*) — an enormous family: *salām* (peace), *islām* (submission → peace with God), *muslim* (“one who submits,” the *mu-i-* pattern), *sallama* (to greet). It reaches past Arabic: Hebrew **shalom** is the *same* Semitic root. English meets it as the borrowing *salaam* and the name *Salīm*.

Why it’s said this way

On its own, *salām* is a warm “peace” — and the seed of the full greeting *as-salāmu ‘alaykum*, coming shortly. To say it is to wish the other person peace, not merely to signal “hello.”

1.2 مرحبا (*marḥaban*) — “hello,” i.e. “there’s room for you”

The letters in this word

Three new letters: ب (*bāʾ*, “b,” one dot *below*), ر (*rāʾ*, a tapped “r,” one-way), ح (*ḥāʾ*, a heavy, throaty “h”). With م and ل from *salām*, read باب (*bāb*, “door”), حب (*ḥubb*, “love”), then مرحبا right to left → *marḥaban*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مرحبا (*marḥaban*), the casual “hi.” Root **r-h-b** (*spaciousness*): *raḥba* (to be wide), *raḥb* (roomy) → *marḥaban* = “[a place of] welcome, there is room for you.” Not an empty sound but a little sentence — as *buenos días* was once a blessing. Reply: *marḥabtayn*, “two welcomes.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Dots on a shared skeleton distinguish many letters: ب / ت / ث (b / t / th) are one shape with one dot below / two above / three above. Learn one skeleton and you often get three letters.

1.3 ال (al-) — “the,” hiding in English *algebra*

The letters in this word

No new letters — just ا (alif) and ل (lām), the two you already read in *salām*, written together and attached to the front of a noun.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ال (*al-*, “the”). For ~800 years Arabic was the Mediterranean’s language of science and trade, and English and Spanish absorbed its words *with al- attached*: **algebra** (*al-jabr*), **alcohol** (*al-kuḥl*), **algorithm** (*al-Khwārizmī*), **alchemy**, **almanac**. Learning Arabic *al-* is meeting an old friend.

Grammar Lens

Sun letters. Before certain consonants (س *s*, ش *sh*, ن *n*, ر *r*, ت *t*...) the *l* of *al-* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al- + salām* → *as-salām*; *al- + nūr* → *an-nūr*. Before “moon letters” (خ *kh*, ك *k*...) the *l* stays: *al-khayr*. You can hear the rule inside Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*).

1.4 السلام عليكم (*as-salāmu ‘alaykum*) — “peace be upon you”

The letters in this word

Three new letters, all in *‘alaykum*: ع (*‘ayn*, a throat-tightening with no English equal — approximate it), ي (*yā’*, “y”), ك (*kāf*, “k”). The rest you can already read: السلام is *al- + salām*.

السلام عليكم = *as-salāmu* (*al- + salām*, sun-letter *s* assimilated) + *‘alaykum* (“upon you [all]”). Literally “the peace [be] upon you” — and note there is

no word for “is”: Arabic sets the two phrases side by side and lets “is” be understood (where Spanish needs *está*).

Why it’s said this way

The universal greeting; its reply is fixed: **وعليكم السلام** (*wa-‘alaykum as-salām*) — “and upon you the peace.” You give peace; it is returned. Any time, any register, real weight — you are wishing *peace*, not saying “hi.”

1.5 صباح الخير (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*) — “morning of goodness”

The letters in this word

Two new letters: **ص** (*ṣād*, an *emphatic*/heavy “s” — a different letter from **س**) and **خ** (*khāʾ*, a throat-scrape, the same sound as **Spanish j**). With the rest known, read **صباح** (*ṣabāḥ*, “morning”) and **خير** (*khayr*, “goodness”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

صباح (*ṣabāḥ*), root **ṣ-b-h** (dawn/waking: *ṣubḥ* dawn, *aṣbaḥa* “to become, reach morning”). **خير** (*khayr*, “good, goodness”), root **kh-y-r**. Together **صباح الخير** = “morning of the goodness” — *al-khayr* keeps its *l* (moon letter **خ**), a clean contrast with *as-salām*.

Why it’s said this way

Reply: **صباح النور** (*ṣabāḥ an-nūr*) — “morning of the *light*” (*al-* + *nūr*, sun-letter *n* assimilated). You wish goodness; they wish you light.

1.6. مساء الخير (MASĀʾ AL-KHAYR) — “EVENING OF GOODNESS” 7

1.6 مساء الخير (*masāʾ al-khayr*) — “evening of goodness”

The letters in this word

One new mark: ء (*hamza*), a glottal stop — the catch in the middle of “uh-oh.” At the end of مساء it gives *masāʾ*. Everything else here you can already read.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مساء (*masāʾ*, “evening”), root **m-s-w**: *amsā* “to become, reach evening” — the exact mirror of *aṣḥaḥa*. Arabic names morning and evening as matched events (each with its own “to become” verb), where French *soir* and Spanish *tarde* both merely meant “late.” مساء الخير = “evening of goodness”; reply مساء النور (*masāʾ an-nūr*).

1.7 شكرا (*shukran*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

Two new letters: ش (*shīn*, “sh” — it is س *plus three dots*) and ك (*kāf*, “k,” met in ‘*alaykum*). Read شكرا right to left → *shukran*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

شكرا (*shukran*), root **sh-k-r** (*gratitude*): *shukr* (thanks), *shākir* (thankful), *mashkūr* (thanked). Look: *shākir* and *mashkūr* sit in the *exact* patterns as *kātib* (writer) and *maktūb* (written) from the root engine — learn a pattern once, it works on every root. (This same root, through Persian, gave Hindi/Urdu *shukriyā*.) Reply: عفو (‘*afwan*), “it’s nothing.”

1.8 The day of greetings

When	Greeting	Reply
casual	<i>marḥaban</i>	<i>marḥabtayn</i>
any time	<i>as-salāmu ‘alaykum</i>	<i>wa-‘alaykum as-salām</i>
morning	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>	<i>ṣabāḥ an-nūr</i>
evening	<i>masā’ al-khayr</i>	<i>masā’ an-nūr</i>
thanks	<i>shukran</i>	<i>‘afwan</i>

Read these back right to left before checking: السلام عليكم, مرحبا, سلام. شكرا, مساء الخير, صباح الخير. About a dozen letters, each learned inside a real greeting. Two engines did the work: the three-consonant **root** (s-l-m, sh-k-r) and the attached **al-** with its sun/moon assimilation. Next chapter: introducing yourself (*ismī...*, “my name is”) and how Arabic marks “you” by gender (*anta* / *anti*).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

اسمي أرُون. (*ismī Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
ما اسمك؟ (*mā ismuka* — “What is your name?”)

Built from Chapter 1’s letters and roots, each piece taken apart, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/AR-CO2-*.md.*

2.1 اسم (*ism*) — “name”

The letters in this word

No new letters — ا (*alif*), س (*sīn*), م (*mīm*) are all from Chapter 1. Read اسم right to left → *ism*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

اسم (*ism*, “name”), root **s–m–w**. It is a **Semitic** word, the cousin of Hebrew *shem* (“name”) — the same pairing you saw with *salām* / *shalom*. It has *no* tie to the Indo-European *name* / Latin *nōmen*: Arabic belongs to a different family entirely, and its word for “name” is its own.

2.2 ي (-ī) — “my,” a letter stuck on the end

The letters in this word

ي (*yāʾ*), met in *‘alaykum*, here does a new job: attached to the end of a noun it means “my.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Arabic doesn’t use a separate word for “my” — it **glues a suffix** onto the noun: اسم (*ism*, “name”) + ي (-ī, “my”) = اسمي (*ismī*, “my name”). This is the same trick as the attached *al-* from Chapter 1: Arabic loves to build meaning by fastening little pieces onto a word, not by stringing separate words together.

2.3 ... اسمي (*ismī ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

اسمي (my name) + name = **ismī ...** *Ismī Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is” — again. Recall from *as-salāmu ‘alaykum* (Ch. 1) that Arabic sets two words side by side and lets “is” be understood. So *ismī Arun* is literally “my-name Arun.” Arabic shares this **zero copula** with the Dravidian languages (Tamil *en peyar Arun*) — a striking meeting of two unrelated families on the same habit.

2.4 أنت (*anta / anti*) — “you,” marked by *gender*

The letters in this word

Two new letters: أ (*alif* with a *hamza* seat, a glottal “a”-start) and ت (*tāʾ*, “t” — the ب/ت/ث skeleton from Ch. 1, two dots above). The final vowel is written only with a mark: أنت *anta*, أنتِ *anti*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أنت is “you” — but Arabic splits it by the listener’s **gender**: *anta* to a man, *anti* to a woman. (Root of the pronoun aside, note the shared Semitic *-ta/-ti* ending, the same *t* that marks “you” in Hebrew *atta/att*.)

Grammar Lens

A different axis of “you.” The European and Dravidian tracks split “you” by *register* (familiar vs. respectful — *tū/vous*, *nī/nīṅgaḷ*). Arabic splits it by *gender*: *anta* (to a man) vs. *anti* (to a woman). Same pronoun, a wholly different distinction — you choose by *who you’re talking to*, not how formal you are.

2.5 ما (mā) — “what”

The letters in this word

No new letters: م (*m*) + ا (*alif*, long *ā*) → ما *mā* — the little word you already read as a warm-up in Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ما (*mā*, “what”) is the everyday question-word for things. (Arabic has a second, *mādhā*, for “what” before verbs; *mā* is the one you want before a noun, as in “what [is] your name?”)

2.6 ما اسمك؟ (mā ismuka / ismuki) — “what’s your name?”

اسمك = اسم (*ism*, name) + ك (*kāf*, the “your” suffix) — and *it too is gendered*: *ismuka* (a man’s name), *ismuki* (a woman’s). So ما اسمك؟ is literally “**what [is] your-name?**” — no “is,” the possessive glued on, the gender in the suffix.

Grammar Lens

Notice the matched pair: “my name” takes ي (*-ī*), “your name” takes ك (*-ka/-ki*). Answer with *ismī Arun*. The suffixes are the whole grammar

of the exchange.

2.7 تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*) — “pleased to meet you”

The letters in this word

Uses ت (*tāʾ*, just met), ش (*shīn*) and ر (*rāʾ*) from Ch. 1, plus ف (*fāʾ*, “f”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*), root **sh-r-f** (*honour, nobility*): *sharaf* (honour), *sharīf* (noble — the English borrowing *sherif* of Mecca, and, distantly, the title behind *sheriff*). *tasharrafnā* means literally “**we have been honoured**” — to meet you is presented as an honour received. A more literal option is فرصة سعيدة (*furṣa saʿīda*, “a happy occasion”).

2.8 The whole exchange

Arabic	English
اسمي ميرا.	My name is Mira.
ما اسمك؟	What’s your name?
اسمي أرون.	My name is Arun.
تشرفنا.	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece from the root-and-suffix engine: *ism* (root s-m-w, Hebrew *shem*), the glued *-ī* (“my”) and *-ka/-ki* (“your”), *tasharrafnā* (root sh-r-f, “honour”). And two Arabic habits: it drops “is” entirely (the **zero copula**, shared with the Dravidian languages), and it marks “you” by **gender** (*anta/anti*), not register. Next chapter: *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“how are you?”) and *al-ḥamdu lillāh* — the responding cycle.